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Charlie Gabriel

Reedman Charlie Gabriel is a native of New Orleans who continues a family musical tradition that goes back four generations. In the month of January, 2020, when this interview was conducted, Charlie was awarded a Lifetime Achievement in Music Award by OffBeat Magazine. *During this interview he reminisced about his career as a saxophonist and clarinetist in Detroit and his eventual return to New Orleans for a steady gig with the Preservation Hall Jazz Band.*

Charlie was interviewed in New Orleans, Louisiana on January 9, 2020 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: I'm very happy to have Charlie Gabriel with me today. My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. Thanks for your time.

CG: Oh thank you for having me. I really appreciate it.

MR: We were just talking about, we're all on the same page now. And I saw on your list of accomplishments that you played behind some of the 50s performers like Frankie Avalon and that.

CG: Oh I played behind them early, later in life I was playing behind them after I left New Orleans and went to Detroit. But I started playing music in New Orleans in 1943 during the war. The war was going on and all the musicians that were able to go to the war, were 20 or 25, they were all gone so there was no other musicians around here but the older musicians like T-Boy Remy, Freddie Keppard or Kid Clayton, Jim Robinson and George Lewis. So what had happened, I come from a musical family. My family moved here to New Orleans in 1856. My grandfather was — great-grandfather was a bass player. My grandfather was a trumpet player, and my father and grandfather were born in New Orleans here, and my father was born in New Orleans, but my great-grandfather was born in Santo Domingo in the Dominican Republic Island. And they all was musicians. So they moved to New Orleans in 1856. My dad had eleven kids, and I had five brothers. And they was all musicians. My father had, I'll tell you their names in a minute, my father had two brothers that I grew up knowing, it was my Uncle Percy and my Uncle Clarence. My Uncle Percy was a bass player that worked at that time with the Jay McShann band. He was with the Jay McShann band. And my Uncle Clarence, he was a piano player and a guitar player — a banjo player. There wasn't no guitar at that time. A banjo player. And my dad was a drummer and later on became a saxophonist after he came down with arthritis, he became a saxophonist. My mother played saxophone, see? So I had a musical life from the time I came into the world.

MR: Can I ask you a question about the music that you were hearing and that your father played and your uncles. Did you call it something? Did you call it jazz? Or was it just —

CG: I have never heard too much of the word jazz until later on after I got to be around 14 or 15, you heard the word jazz. But that word was, from what I can understand Freddie Keppard was a member of my grandfather's band which was the National Jazz Band here in New Orleans in 1920, see? And he was offered a recording contract to record the music. And Freddie Keppard decided he didn't want to record the music because he didn't want them to steal his style of playing. So he put a handkerchief over his finger and he played the trumpet. He didn't want them to see what he was doing. That was Freddie Keppard. So I didn't hear nothing about the word jazz. But when I heard the recorded jazz back in 1926, something like that, '24, '26 it was a white group that recorded the jazz, and recorded the music, so I was told, what kind of music is this? And they said, "Dixieland." But that wasn't the right word to say. It was from the land of Dixie. It wasn't Dixieland. It was from the land of Dixie see? But the media accepted the term Dixieland because at the time I was playing with these old musicians, you know they wasn't broadcasting black people's music. Black people would say, "Oh that was jassy, J-A-S-S." That was the word. And then they changed the word to J-A-Z-Z. Jazz. Now that was handed down to me. I can not vouch on what I'm saying but it was handed down from the older musicians that I was playing with. Because every time they would call my father to play, my father would be working and he'd say, "Oh no, I can't take that job, but you can take the kid" because I could read good at 12, and 11 or 12, I could read good because I started learning at 7. So when I got to be 11 years old I was almost like a professional musician because all the old musicians would call my father and he couldn't take the job. He'd say, "Well you can take the kid." That gave me an opportunity to play with Jim Robinson, play with George Lewis, play with T–Boy Remy, to play with Kid Sheik, to play with all the older musicians. I was all their little boy.

MR: What was it like interacting with those older fellas?

CG: Well my dad was very disciplined. He'd say, "Now whatever they tell you to do you do." So I didn't rebel against none of them. In fact I remember one time I was with Eureka band and George Lewis was playing right next to me. I'm playing right next to George Lewis. And I must have been making a mistake or something or doing something, because I couldn't play out of my head. I could read but when they played something out of their head then I'd be stumbling, you know, trying to play with them. So George Lewis said, he looked down at me and giving me something. My dad said, "No, don't help him, don't help him, let him play, let him learn, let him play like a man. So they can pay him like a man. I was about 12, 13 years old.

MR: You said you were a good reader, but not all that music was written out, was it?

CG: Well some of that music was written out because you see they played a lot of dirges, a lot of the jobs I played was funerals. They played a lot, and the first job I had was a funeral. That was the first job I had in my life was a funeral. So they had the music on an itty bitty card like this. A dirge, or I can't think of the different dirges I played, but I could read them and play them. But after they leave the body, took it to the cemetery, and we walked away from the graveyard maybe about a block away from the graveyard, they uplifted the music from playing the dirge into much more lively stuff to help the people that lost their loved one to kind of get back into their normal self instead of grieving. But as the band picked up these numbers and people were walking on the street and picked up these numbers, just anybody in the street would hear this music and they'd start coming to the band, coming to hear the band. And so they are playing uptempo stuff. They ain't playing nothing slow, now uptempo stuff. And that started what you call the "second line." The people joined and they didn't even know the deceased but they joined in and followed the band and they would have a good time. And what they'd do is that wherever the person, the deceased, where he used to go and drink at and hang out at, the band would go to those places where they would hang out at and they would be giving beer out and everything and everybody would have a good time, to celebrate his life. So because they could have free drinks, more people would come, so it would be a big thing. And if he was a well known musician or well known person, in whatever profession and they had some of this for ladies too from different organizations, they had funerals for them the same way they had for jazz musicians.

MR: Who was responsible for paying the musicians?

CG: Who would be responsible for paying the musicians?

MR: Yes.

CG: The band leader.

MR: And who paid him?

CG: Well he'd have a contract. For the funeral or something like that?

MR: Yes.

CG: Well I would state he had a contract, but someone gives him X amount of dollars to take care of the person that you are using. But I never had a job myself as the band leader to play a funeral.

MR: I just was curious if the family of the deceased —

CG: It probably is the family of the deceased. Well they still pay for funerals and things. And they also not only pay for the funeral, when they take them to the different churches they give the people in the church money too sometimes you know. Because the only people that come to see the loved one that has gone, they're still sad but they're so thankful you've been so nice to them during that period of time through their mourning and

everything else. It's a beautiful thing. It's a ritual that we've been — it kind of opened my eyes up when they were doing this, so I imagine they were doing it for a long time before I opened my eyes up, because those were older guys, older musicians, and it didn't happen just when I come into the world, it was already going on. I just followed the path.

MR: You can have your coffee, go ahead. I'm always curious what musicians made during different periods.

CG: It would vary you know. It wasn't a whole lot of money because whatever it was was according to the time, it was during that period of time. I guess they had a union because I couldn't be seen in the band when the union man came around. They just had me aside and covered me up with two or three guys would probably stand in front me so the union man don't see me but he knew too, because he knew the musicians and it didn't bother them too much but you know how that goes.

MR: How old were you supposed to be?

CG: No age limit but I just wasn't in the union.

MR: Oh you weren't in the union, of course.

CG: If I'd have joined the union they wouldn't bother me. I wasn't in the union. But I had an uncle in the union and he was on the Board. His name was August Lenoir. He was married to my father's sister. So they didn't bother me too much because I had a little clout.

MR: You had a little connection there.

CG: Yeah.

MR: And were you playing tenor or clarinet?

CG: Clarinet. E flat clarinet. E flat clarinet. And George Lewis was playing an E flat clarinet. You knew Georgie Lewis?

MR: Yeah, sure. I wonder why the E flat because it just rang out?

CG: E flat because that's the instrument that rang out. The pitch is so high. And it carried over the band, that E flat clarinet. The B flat clarinet would be lost in there.

MR: What's that famous clarinet solo?

CG: "High Society?"

MR: "High Society." Yeah.

CG: [scats] Yeah. That was "High Society." Now that was written by Picou — he wrote that for the flute. It wasn't a clarinet thing. But it became a clarinet thing, it was a way of measuring the musician's ability. If you can play "High Society," see, then you had the ability to play in the band you know. It was a measuring stick, see? Just like John Coltrane, his measurement was, what was that Coltrane —

MR: "Giant Steps?"

CG: "Giant Steps." That was his measuring stick. And these other musicians, their measuring stick was —

MR: Who are you talking about?

CG: They all had measuring sticks. In other words, you had to come up to a certain level in order to qualify to play. If you can't come up to that level you couldn't be a part of this thing. Folks, we still were teaching the other musicians how to play and what to use in order to develop their skill you know. "Cherokee" — that's the one I was think —

MR: Oh right. With Charlie Parker.

CG: Well Charlie Parker came in with a whole thing and knocked all of that out, see? When Charlie Parker came in, him and Diz, they changed the whole concept of jazz. So on Charlie Parker's break on "Night in Tunisia" they wrote seven books on it. See? "Night in Tunisia" just the break alone, they're not talking about his solos you know. But you'll get a little piece of that here and there. I was fortunate enough that when I went to Detroit in 1948, I went to Detroit in '48, I was lucky enough to be a well established musician. I was only about 17 years old and I'd been playing since I was 11 so I was pretty well advanced. I had an opportunity to do a thing with Lionel Hampton for a little short thing. I didn't stay with Hamp's band at all. I did a couple of little things with him and I was fortunate to move on with other top jazz musicians, you know.

MR: Yeah. In 1948 Lionel Hampton was sort of headed towards almost rhythm & blues, wasn't he?

CG: No, no. Lionel Hampton in 1948, I replaced Illinois Jacquet you know?

MR: Oh you replaced him.

CG: I didn't replace him, in other words I played the solo after the Illinois Jacquet and so it gave me a little chance to try and be with that band. But I didn't stay with that band at all. I just did a couple of things with them while they were in the City of Detroit.

MR: I see.

CG: At the Paradise Theater. But I was an old musician being young. Hampton liked me, because when he auditioned me he auditioned me with two fingers, like that. Like he was playing the vibes. You know?

MR: He was playing the piano with two fingers.

CG: Two fingers. He made the chord changes with two fingers and all that. But it was good. I've been very blessed musically speaking because I've worked with some of the greatest musicians in the country. I did a thing with, I was fortunate to be on a couple of things with Benny Carter on a couple of festivals. And I did things with Jay McShann, we did a couple of things at the Tarrytown Concert House. In Ann Arbor, Michigan I recorded with him but that was never released. I stayed with — J.C. Heard and Dizzy Gillespie was in the Cab Calloway band together. J.C. Heard told me, he told me that, so every

time Dizzy Gillespie would come through Detroit, he'd be at J.C.'s home, so I had a chance to mingle with Dizzy Gillespie, which was very fortunate you know. Because I stayed with J.C. nine years. That's the longest I stayed with one band. And before I went with J.C. I went with Aretha Franklin. I worked with the Aretha Franklin band before I got with J.C. Heard.

MR: Well you and I have one thing in common.

CG: What?

MR: I got to play in the sax section with Aretha Franklin one time.

CG: Ah. Wonderful. That's wonderful.

MR: Unforgettable.

CG: Yes, she had some beautiful charts.

MR: She sure does.

CG: But you know when I got to Aretha Franklin's band, Donald Towns was the band leader.

MR: Who is that?

CG: Donald Towns was the band leader. And he brought me in the band, and I went in on alto. I went in on alto and I'm playing third alto. And the band was leaving to go to France, yeah, they were leaving to go to France. And the baritone player at the last minute told Aretha he wasn't going. "You're not going? We have everything all set." Well we've got to go. When they got over to France they had a brand new baritone sax there for me to play, so they put me on baritone. So I wound up playing baritone with Aretha Franklin. Not tenor. It was a trip. What happened when I went to France, Chips Outcalt, used to be with Billy Eckstine's band, Billy Eckstine. But he was playing trombone in Billy Eckstine's band. He played trumpet and trombone but he was playing trombone but he was a great arranger. Him and Quincy, Quincy Jones, from what I understand it was told to me but I can't vouch on that, but Quincy Jones was under J.C. — under Chips, see? But he was also in Lionel Hampton's band you know. So he did a little studying under Chips with his writing, see? It used to be speed writing. An act would come into the Apollo Theater or something and play, and they have no music. There are about three or four arrangers, and that's how they hustled and made money, see? Because you need music for your act? Boom they'd start the writing. And when your act is finished they give you the chart.

MR: Oh, no computer either, right?

CG: No, not there. Not there writing. So Chips became a very close friend of mine. He came to Detroit, lived in Detroit, so he was also a member of Aretha Franklin's band too. Chips was in Aretha Franklin's band too, also Marcus Belgrave. Me and Marcus stayed together for about seven years, we had a little group together, me and Marcus. Cut a few records. They've got a few records out. And we just lost Marcus about a couple of years ago.

MR: Didn't Billy Mitchell come from —

CG: Billy Mitchell, yeah, the tenor player from Detroit, too. I mean, you know, Detroit musicians that are in New York are Detroiters. They first migrated to New York in the 40s, see? That would be Thad Jones and Elvin Jones and all of those guys, they migrated to New York in the 40s. I got out of the service in '55 and the cats was getting together to go to New York and they asked me, "Charlie, we're going to New York, you want to go with me, man?" "I ain't going to New York and starve to death. No man." 'Cause my uncles had already warned me about coming to New York. They had, my mother's brother had the "Salad Green Show" out of New Orleans that folded down in 1931. The "Salad Green Show." You ever heard? Look it up. Ethel Waters was on the show and Bill Robinson was on the show. So I had music from both sides in my family that were dealing with this music. That's all we ever did. That's all I ever did. I have never worked a day in my life other than play music, see? Other than play music I never did anything else but play music. And my father taught me. I didn't go to no college and no school like that. My music was taught from my dad down. I had five brothers. My brother Martin, the older one, played trumpet; August played trumpet too. And I wanted to play trumpet, my Daddy said, "No, no, no, all you guys playing trumpet, we ain't getting no money in this house." Somebody's got to play something else.

MR: Why is that?

CG: Well if all of us played trumpet he'd only hire one trumpet player. So he gave me no money. You had to play something to bring some money into the house, to help to support the family. You know what I mean? So he told me and my cousin Clarence Ford, you ever heard of Clarence Ford? Clarence Ford is my cousin. My dad caught Clarence Ford and me together. He caught us fooling with what you call a potato whistle. We was in the yard and we had a potato whistle. It was like a potato but it had three holes on the top and three holes there and one on the bottom. See? They had one, and we played the whistle by numbers. One — one, two, three, four, five, six, or whatever it is. And we had a little song, number two, and I'd play and Clarence played. And he says, "You boys want to learn how to play music? My dad said, "Come on in here." He took us in the house and he sat us down and he started teaching us the clarinet. I think my cousin Ford — he got a C clarinet for my cousin Ford — no he gave me the C clarinet. He gave me the C clarinet. So when he arrived he was writing all violin parts for me to play.

MR: Hmm. You got the hard stuff.

CG: I'll never forget — I'll never forget he wrote an arrangement on "How Deep is the Ocean" [sings] how deep is the ocean [scats]. So when the band was playing [scats] I played the obbligato [scats] like a violin. So I learned a lot. Yeah. I learned a lot.

MR: That's a great story. How much of the music, the years you spent in Detroit, obviously music, the styles changed over the years.

CG: Why sure. When I went to Detroit I stopped playing clarinet for about twenty years 'cause there wasn't no jobs for clarinet. But only when I played with a band, a big band, eight, nine, ten pieces, they had some parts for the clarinet which was always good. Because you'd get paid for each instrument I play. I played the flute too. So I played the clarinet, tenor and flute, see? So I tried to learn that instrument if they're going to pay me for it. Yeah.

MR: Did you have to adapt to the rock & roll that came on to the scene, because the tenor players always got the —

CG: That was a natural for me because when I played "Flying Home" with Lionel Hampton that's one of the things that got me into that band. Because Charlie Mingus was in the band at that time. You know? So I'd play the horn and, you know, I mean you'd go all out to entertain the public. I can't stand there just blowing my horn you know and look cute you know? You have to move, entertain people. It's two types of ways of playing. Like I have to tell these guys at the club here right now, when you're playing jazz, like we like to play, the people come and they sit and they have their drink and they listen. They're not jumping up and down. They're listening. It's a listening music. Now when you go to a club where they've got a bottle of beer in their hand and a drink over here, they want to be entertained. They don't want you to just sit up there and then blow all them notes. No. Show me something, baby. You know? Let me feel the beat. And the beat goes on, you know? So that's important to know the difference of the type of job that you're playing. And if you're doing things in hotels like this, you've got a piano ensemble with a horn thing, you play music for people to listen 'cause they're eating. You don't want to play things that disturb. They've got to learn all that, that this is a part of the business. Music is a business, see? And it's a full time business you know? Because it's all over the world because music is the strongest force we have. It's on top of everything. It soothes you down and brings all the best of you out. See? Even with your girlfriend, if you talk right and sing songs right, she'll come back. Music is the strongest force we have. So I pay a lot of attention to that and I pay a lot of attention to the audience that I'm performing in front of. You know?

MR: Good advice. Did your father talk about those kinds of things like beyond how good you play the saxophone or the clarinet, you have to behave like this. Did he give you advice?

CG: My dad was so strict. You have to behave, just like you say, like in this type of environment. This type of material we play, now we're going to play for so-and-so now all this is going to be from this age on up so you've got to pay attention to the music that you're playing. You have to live the music as you play it. You have to live it. The music

is generally an extension of what you are because you have to live it in order to deliver it. And if you live it you can deliver it you know. But if you don't live it you're just playing and then she's not going to feel it. She's not going to feel it unless you feel it. If you feel it you're going to deliver it and she's going to feel it too.

MR: I'm feeling it. Okay so I'm thinking about your career and I'm still thinking about in Detroit. Was there a period of years, because of the way music changed, that was the hardest for you to make a living?

CG: When I got to Detroit I never had no problem 'cause I always knew how to govern myself for the type of job that I have. When I got to Detroit I was fortunate enough to meet Clair Rockamore, a little trumpet player. If you read Miles Davis' autobiography you'll see his name in there. Clair Rockamore. Clair Rockamore was a little trumpet player — when Miles came to Detroit he didn't play. He tried to get out of it if you put it that way. He was only about 13, 14 years old, 'cause he also was with me at the time he made the audition to do this thing with Lionel Hampton's band. I was there and he was there. Hamp let me play. But he would take fills from Fats Navarro. Fats Navarro was in the band and Fats Navarro was taking fills with little Clair Rockamore — Clair Rockamore was only 13 years old at that time. I was about 15, 15 or 16, or something like around that time. I was associated with Barry Harris. I had to go to Barry Harris' house, he had all the jazz musicians that was there, we'd jam up there. Barry is very sick, too. I heard he just got back to the States. Anyway, Barry Harris, and Roland Hanna, Sir Roland Hanna. He was a good friend of my brother. He used to come over the house and we'd jam together. He played saxophone too. A lot of people didn't know. Eugene Taylor, Kenny Burrell, all these — even Yusef Lateef you know, was in that area you know? So being around those musicians, they all gave me something because I would jam with them and I learned a lot from them and they got a lot from me. Because I was from New Orleans, and they'd always say boy, you've got that rhythm in you. Me and Marcus tried to create a New Orleans-Detroit communication, whatever you want to call it. We tried to do New Orleans and Detroit. We did pretty good. My dad and my Uncle Percy, they started New Orleans music in Detroit and they were called the Gabriel Brothers Band. I never had no problem, because Joe Hunter, who was a band leader for Motown, we were playing together and he used to like to write a lot. Joe Hunter. And Earl VanDyke who was the Funk Brothers, so we played together even before Motown got to the level that they got at.

MR: Was there a studio scene in Detroit that you'd get called to play?

CG: At that time they didn't have no Motown. They had a place that they called the Specialty Recording. It was on Dauphine Street. And they all said another record company in Detroit was called Fortune Records. And all this was before Berry Gordy. And then they

started migrating together and started working out different things. But there was a lot that happened before Berry. I don't want to tell you about all my downfalls but I have to tell you anyway, because it's true. I was directing for the Joe Simon Band. He was a singer, singing the blues. "Pretty Little Bitty One" you know, Joe sang it. He was at the Apollo Theater and he had the big headline and they had, under him, the Five Step Brothers and the Jackson 5. So I went — Five Step Brothers came on first and I heard them little kids playing. I said, "Oh man, look at them kids playing this music." I went back and I told Joe, I says, "Joe, you've got to come out here and see these kids play this music." "Oh, man, don't worry about that." This was the Five Step Brothers. "I wouldn't worry about that." He's the headlines. So after Five Step Brothers came out then the Jackson 5 came out. Joe Jackson was playing the guitar. And his group, his brothers were all over the thing — and I saw, I said, oh man they've got to come and see these kids. These kids is badder than these other kids. He goes, "Aww, don't worry about it." I said okay. Then he came out on that stage, and man, them boys burnt that stage — that stage was so hot. I'm the director and I said, "Okay fellas, here" [scats] "Joe Simon" everybody — the curtain opened up and he comes walking out there and the people just looked at him. He couldn't do nothing. That stage was too hot. He started singing "Frankie and Johnny went hunting" — or whatever that was. Them two boys — I met old man Joe, he talked to me and he said man, I need some help with these kids, by me being in the band. I said, "Well may I say I'm trying to talk to Joe, to get Joe to talk to you, 'cause they had a recording company in Nashville, and maybe we can do something with them kids, you know? Nothing happened. I met Joe, I met Michael Jackson then, he was only 11 years old, 11 or 12 years old and blew that thing — Diana Ross came out right back behind me and took them down to Motown and the rest is history. I could have been a millionaire now. That's not bad. But listen to this one. My little nephew came and said, "Uncle Charles, you've got to hear the little blind boy play this piano." He was living on the same block as my nephew, on Humboldt Street, in the same block in Detroit as my brother with my sister. Oh they worried the hell out of us— he said, "Come and hear the blind boy play." I said oh, go and get him. I told Michael — Stevie Wonder. Stevie Wonder come down to my sister's house and he must have been about 10 years old. He came and I said, "Go ahead and play." Oh he was just playing. Well by me being such an old musician I see other young musicians, young kids playing much more than what Stevie playing. To me. Now maybe Stevie was playing a lot but I wasn't paying attention that good. So I said, oh yeah, yeah, and he went on about his business. Two years later Joe Hunter let Stevie Wonder — took him down to Motown. The rest is history. I had some bad breaks.

MR: That could have been another million, your second million.

CG: I had some bad breaks, man. Oh, so I know that would make you laugh. Two giants. I missed both of them. I had more opportunity than anybody.

MR: Oh gee. Well I wanted to ask you about playing in France.

CG: Oh yeah, I'm going to tell you about that.

MR: Yeah. Because I noticed a little story like someone over in France heard you play and said, "You're from New Orleans."

CG: Yeah. What happened. Chips Outcalt wrote an arrangement of "My Way" I did it my way, I told you they told me on baritone. You know? Yeah. And

MR: I'm just — should I move it down a tad? Stop.

@ approximately 35:36

CG: They were going to feature me on "My Way" and so Chips wrote the arrangements so we were rehearsing it in the place and there was a guy way in the back, and I got off the bandstand and he walked up to me and okay, say, "You're from New Orleans." I said, "No, man, I'm with Aretha Franklin, man, I'm from Detroit." He said, no, he shook his head, he said, "No. You're from New Orleans." He said, "What your name is?" No first he said, "It's in your music, you're from New Orleans." He said, "What's your name is?" I said, "I'm Charlie Gabriel." He said, "You know Manny Gabriel?" I said, "Yeah, that's my father." He said, and he called, "Mabel Gabriel?" And Alice Gabriel, and just women's names. I said, "I don't know them" but I found out he liked me anyway, he was a very fine man, he liked me and he — see he took me around to see Sidney Bechet's statue — to me a Sidney Bechet statue, and I'm looking at the statue. I found out that he knew my grandfather, because he used to live here in New Orleans and he knew my grandfather. He was in music but I don't know what he was in. But he and my grandfather, and that's how he knew who I was musically speaking. So I went back to Detroit and I told, "Dad" I said, "You know you've got it, you're known all over in France." I said, "This guy told me that I was from New Orleans" and I told him what happened. And he said no they don't know me, they call me Little Man. That's what they called my father, Little Man, and called my grandfather Manny. That's how that worked. And so after that happened I went around interviewing all my aunts and uncles that was still living and still in music, so I did a lot of research and found out a lot of stuff that I didn't know nothing about. Because they have closed mouth. They don't tell you nothing, your parents. See my mother speaks French fluently, and anytime they get around her and they'll be speaking to her and Miss Percy will be speaking on the step and everything else, they say, "Oh get out of here, you're too wet around the ears, you want to know too much." You know? Get out of here. So what'd they do? If you didn't get out they'd start speaking French in front of you so you won't know what they're talking about. So I'm sitting up there and my mother and Miss Percy and they're just speaking French because

you don't know what they're saying. And they won't teach you because they don't want you to know. Now on Daddy's side, Daddy speaks Spanish. You know what I mean? So him and her, I don't know how they do that together when they don't want you to know how they can communicate French and Spanish. I don't know.

MR: Because you said your grandfather was from the Dominican —

CG: The Dominican Republic Islands. My great grandfather. My grandfather was born in New Orleans, see? So that was the story on that. So you learn a little bit as you get a little older you learn a little bit more and a little bit more. That's how they got the chance to get to Detroit because my older brother and them, my brother Martin, my brother August, they played trumpet and then they played trombone. Joe, my brother Joe, he played bass. My brother Elliot plays piano, see? And I play the reeds. I couldn't get them to play together to do one record. Couldn't get them, boy I begged them and everything else. Come on you guys, oh they made a couple of rehearsals at the house and the rehearsal went pretty good, and before you know it they're all dancing and rehearsal's over with. I couldn't get them to do it but I loved them. We played together quite a lot, but I couldn't get them to do a record with me. I couldn't get them. That would be good if I had one.

MR: I'm fascinated by the musical family tradition in New Orleans and I'm wondering, was there other traditions where the children were expected to follow the family business? Like being a barber or a plumber? Or is it pretty much just a musical thing?

CG: It's just music — they had no other intent to do anything else. My sisters — I had five sisters. They were just getting off with their boyfriends and getting married and having babies or whatever they wanted to do. I had a large, large, large family. You know what I mean? So the ladies wasn't worrying about music. My mother just played the saxophone when dad asked her to play with him. Dad and her would sit down and play something. But other than that and the other ladies didn't care about that.

MR: Did your mother play gigs?

CG: No. My mother didn't play no gigs. My sister played — I had a sister that played the saxophone. My older sister, she was playing with my dad before I was born. Her name was Florence and she married a guy named Simmons. So he used to tell her, say, "You can't be playing gigs with your dad anymore, you've got to make a family, we've got to do this" whatever. So she stopped playing. But she used to play gigs with my dad, but not my mother.

MR: Okay. I want to go back for a question.

CG: All right.

MR: When you were a kid and you started playing with the bands for the funerals and so forth —

CG: No my dad — go ahead —

MR: Yeah. Were there any women allowed to be playing in those groups or were their white and black musicians together?

CG: There were white and black musicians. See, that's what a lot of people don't know. First the bands were all black. Then you had a lot of black guys playing in the white band and passing. Paso blanc. You know? So and here in New Orleans you can do whatever you want to do. Like even the dark skinned guys would cross the color line, they would put a rag on their head just like they were in Africa or someplace, and then go in all those restaurants just like anybody else, and they won't know who they are. See? That's how that was.

MR: The darker skinned —

CG: Dark skinned people — you know they don't even think of the complexion, this idea that you're going to have something that represents another country, you can come in. But if you are passing, you know, paso blanco, you can do something, you go over.

MR: What's that term you just used?

CG: Paso blanc.

RB: Pass for white.

MR: Pass for white.

CG: It means pass over. All my mother's deal — they never did let her be black. And every job she got they gave it to her as a white lady. See? And we accepted her as a white lady. The money was white lady.

MR: Do you have a family tree written out?

CG: Oh man yeah, my sister got a family tree and she lives in Wichita, Kansas. A lot of this stuff — they got another book out written by my cousin Larry Gabriel. My father played old time music. And in that book you will see some of that information. You got that?

MR: I have some of it right here. Very fascinating. In fact I think he was talking about you. "We went playing straight to the bar. It was hot and everyone in the band started drinking, 15 or 20 minutes the trumpet played the trumpet, called for the musicians to get back in time."

CG: Yep. It's a funny family, some things. Some of that stuff they might have to edit it out, but I will leave it to you with some discretion how it hits the public. You know? Sometimes you say things one way and they're taking it another way. See? That do happen. It's how you present it to them. But I just speak what I feel and what I know.

MR: Yeah. Was there any down side to trying to make a living as a musician, either with you or your friends?

CG: Well there's always a down side because usually depending on people having parties and having weddings and having a birth, you see? A lot of other things come into focus other than just playing in the club or playing a festival you know. There's a lot of other things

come in focus. So you hit today, miss tomorrow, hit two or three more days and miss the next day. I have experienced that, all through my life, as far as hitting the road, I don't want to tell you some of the hardships but I've been exposed to the other side of it where you miss what we call, you miss so many meals, see? You miss a meal because — I'll give you one idea. I had a group on the road, a trio. And we were working in Appleton, Wisconsin and my drummer, a white boy because I had a mixed trio, he overplayed his hand with this young lady, he overplayed his hand. And he was buying drinks and everything, and playing big shot. When it was time for us to check out of the hotel he took all our money — my wages and the trumpet, because he overpaid himself and he had to pay his bill. Pay our bill and have to pay his bill. And we were leaving from Appleton, Wisconsin going to Rapid City, South Dakota. Where the presidents are in the mountain, wherever that is. We got there and we had, between the three of us we had $10 between the three of us. You know? So man, what are we going to do? We've got to make it. Well the policy in the band, what I had made up, that we don't tab — we don't draw down no money, we don't tab no drinks. Because people don't know what you have in your pocket unless you put your hand in and bring out nothing, you know? And if you're looking good, they didn't know what you have in your pocket. You have to look the part and act the part. We had no money. And so I said well I'm going to go to the priest, I'm a Catholic, and let him know, and just spread that I need some money to run us the week, and I'll bring the money back to him over the weekend. I went to see the priest and I told Father my condition. And Father went in his pocket and pulled out some chunk change, about 5 or 6 dollars. Something like that. I said, oh I need more than that. He said well — that's that. Now I only had 5 or 6 dollars so we went to the store and we bought a box of Ritz, a box of Ritz and a big bottle of peanut butter. And we put the Ritz — the peanut butter inside the Ritz and marked three in the morning for breakfast, three for lunch and three for dinner. And that's hard.

MR: That's hard times.

CG: So I don't mean to laugh at that, but that's okay.

MR: It makes for a great story now, doesn't it?

CG: Yeah. But that's one of them. We do have some other ones but that one there stands out in my mind all the time. And what really made it really bad, you're playing at the Air Force base, Suffolk Air Field Base, that's what it was. And everything was coming from the kitchen to serve the soldiers and thing on the table, and you could smell that good food coming and you'd smell it gone, and you'd smell the bones going back. I know you wanted some more, to hear that. I know you didn't want to hear that but I told it to you anyway.

MR: That's a good one. Enough to make you want to go find a uniform and put it on so you could sit down and eat.

CG: I was only booked there for one week so that didn't last too long. We recovered.

MR: Well I guess you didn't hold a grudge against the Catholic church because didn't later on you do some jazz masses?

CG: I wrote a jazz mass. And who did I write this for — my niece, first of all I have a niece who is a pianist and a music director in the church. And that story was kind of funny, because I was in Indonesia, I was in Indonesia and something hit me that said to write a mass, the music for the mass. And my niece, being the director, she was in New Orleans and I was in Indonesia and I called her and I said, "Marjorie," she said, "Yeah." I said, "What do you do when the priest doing so and so and something." Everything I wanted to know I asked her. I'm in Indonesia and she said, "When I do so-and-so-and-so." I said, "What do you play at that time." See "The Lamb of God." I said in "The Lamb of God" okay. The "Our Father" and the different parts of the mass. So I wound up writing the music for the mass while I was in Indonesia. You know I've got a beautiful "Our Father." Beautiful. So anyway to make a long story short, I wrote the music for the mass and in the name of God I said, okay, I'll say I wrote "The Lamb of God" on a napkin — whole tones [sings] name of God/will take away the sins of the world/Have mercy on us — these whole tones [sings] Name of God/Who takes away — and a whole tone down — the sins of the world. Have mercy/grant us peace. Okay. That worked out fine. [sings] Lord have mercy/Lord have mercy/Lord have mercy/Have mercy on us. Christ have mercy/Christ have mercy/Christ have mercy/Have mercy on us. And that was during "The Name of God," and that was [scats] I can't think of the words. Anyway, that was the Halleluiah. [sings] Halleluiah, Halleluiah, Halleluiah, Halleluiah. That's one part. That's the part they sing. And the other part — [sings] Halle-halle-lu-halle-lu [scats]Oh I loved that Halleluiah because me and Marcus, on the part they had twenty voices. And one voice would be playing — one group would be saying [sings] Halleluiah, Halleluiah, Halleluiah, Halleluiah. And the other part would be saying [sings] Halleluiah, Halleluiah, Halleluiah, Halleluiah. And the other voice would be [sings Halle-halle-lu-iah, Halle-halle-lu-iah, Halle-halle-lu-iah. Oh that was great.

MR: Nice.

CG: That's the jazz mass at St. Francis DeSales.

MR: Where was the first — oh DeSales. We have a DeSales in Utica, DeSales Center.

CG: Yeah, I wrote that for St. Francis DeSales.

MR: Was that the first time it was performed? At the DeSales.

CG: Yeah. Francis. Yeah. And it was just — I've had a beautiful, I've been having a — everything that I asked God for he has given to me. I just can't — that might make no

sense to somebody, but when I was seven years old and started playing music I asked God I said I want to be a musician. I want to play music and I want to play music so I can play with any band around the world. If they want a saxophone player they'll call me all the time, they'll call me to come and play with them. And believe me, as I sit in front of you, I've had musicians that called me from France, from London, from Switzerland, from Indonesia, I can go on and on and on. I've been exposed to them when I was with other bands around the country and things, and they got to be friends of mine. And I have received everything I asked God for. God has blessed me in abundance. Right now I'm about to receive another, what is that, "Lifetime Achievement Award." I'm going to receive that sometime this month. What do they call it? *OffBeat* Magazine. You seen one of them yet? You seen one?

MR: No.

CG: Well I'm on the front page of the *OffBeat* Magazine.

MR: All right, we'll look for that.

CG: And a lot of stuff I'm telling you is in the story of the *OffBeat* Magazine. They are free. They are free. They put them around the country.

MR: Okay. We'll find one.

CG: Yeah, they're free.

MR: Before we wrap up I wanted to talk about your return to New Orleans. Was it Ben Jaffe who called you?

CG: Ben Jaffe, what a wonderful man. Ben and I have a beautiful connection. When he brought me back down here he was fooling with the banjo, playing something on the banjo. He's a wonderful person, a fine musician. He finished from Oberlin, you know? And I'm listening to all these chord changes he was playing on his banjo, and I said, "Ben, that is really nice but you need a melodic line on top of those changes." He said, "You want to put one?" I said yeah. So I came up with a line, "Yellow Moon." [scats] Something like that. I can't remember. We recorded it. It's on one of these albums. And then, by him being a bass player we connected really good because he had the bottom of the chords you know, I could hear the chords and all I'd do is put a line on top of them.

MR: Yeah. But you've got to have the bottom.

CG: Yeah. The body that don't have no bottom ain't got no top. Yeah Ben is one, he plays bass in the band, Ben Jaffe. And sometimes he'll play the banjo in certain things. We did that "Yellow Moon" with a group of ballet dancers and they danced on it. Yeah. We did this about two years with a ballet team and they danced on the "Yellow Moon" you know? It was wonderful. I'm getting in all kinds of situations.

MR: And so when you — I don't think the camera was rolling when we were talking about playing at Preservation Hall and sometimes subs come in if they're needed but you won't just play with anybody.

CG: I put it this way: I have never turned no one down to play with. I always play with them. But after I play with them and everything else and if I have a problem they have other musicians that replace them. We've got about 70 musicians associated at the hall, so why take the worst one when they've got so many more. But you don't turn nothing away. You still reach him the best way you can. And try to deliver what they need in order to become a better person, a better musician. I ran into that sometime and me being as old as I am I know how the older guys treated me so I try to treat them like I was treated. See? I don't look back — the only way they're going to get it is if you hand it down to them, see? And show them the best way to get to what they're doing — I, a lot of times — a musician that played with me a lot of times I'd be warming up and I'd be trying to warm up on things that would be enough to test their ear that they would ask me about it, then I would show it to them. See? I got them doing a lot of diminished chord but then if you got three of them there you put each one on a different note and play the same phrase [scats]. I say, "You're starting on a G, you're starting on an E, you're starting on a C sharp" [scats]. See? I do that on "Limehouse" [scats]. "Limehouse." If you'd a came the other day you'd have heard me doing it.

MR: Is it okay if I borrow that lick from you?

CG: You can take that. And an easy way of taking it, it's nothing but a B diminished starting on a C sharp [scats] C sharp, E and G, B flat, C sharp E and G on up. So you put each one of them on one part of the diminished. You were on the C sharp, I was on the E, the trumpet player is on the G, the other player is on the B flat. See? And you play that all the way up the line. And come down with [scats] See? You come on down with it. And also with the augmented. Flat 5 augmented — going up — flat 5 coming down [scats]. Coming down A 7 flat 5. In other words it would be C, B flat, G flat. B flat, A flat, E natural coming down. Going up it's C, E, G. So going up augmented, coming down flat five.

MR: Nice.

CG: I know you got it. You already see it in your head. I know. Isn't that right?

MR: I'm a saxophone player so I'm watching your fingers. I'm okay.

CG: I know you could see it too.

MR: Exactly.

CG: And you see how it works, it works out good.

MR: Way back in the interview you said something about Dixieland, and you said, "No, the land of Dixie." Now at Preservation Hall if someone came from out of town and met you and they said, "What kind of jazz do you play at the Preservation Hall?" —

CG: Traditional. Traditional. That's the name of the music that we play. Because if you play a song in 1920, play the song, and then it's two thousand and something, we are just doing — it's traditional. We're playing the same song as another period of time. What makes the song different is that in the 20s you lived this way and then in the two thousands our lifestyle changes. So we are the music. The music on the paper don't tell you nothing. You are the music. And what you do and how you live and what you've been exposed to comes out in the music. Now if you play saxophone, the saxophone is an extension of your organs. If you blow, you can take the horn away and all you've got is air. But you put it into your horn and start blowing it, what makes — your organs make that note come out as an extension of who you are. That's what I mean. So you're playing traditional music and your horn is an extension of who you are. It's your organs. Otherwise the horn don't do nothing by itself. See? So, and if the horn don't do nothing by itself, whatever you're playing is the music. And if you are the music what kind of music are you playing? You are the music. But they stay on the paper, that's the problem. A lot of guys they play everything. They take it off the paper but they never play it, they're just still memorizing the notes and they're playing — you have to make that music become who you are. Whatever you are. I could play "Rose Room" [scats lazily] she's not going to feel none of that. No. But if you [scats brightly] you're going to feel it because you are, and to be able to project the feeling that makes you feel good it will help to make her feel good. But if you memorize, I have memorized a lot of songs and don't be playing it. Playing the notes but don't be playing the song because I never did learn it. I just took it off the paper and just memorized it. You've got to learn the song and if you're really good you try to learn the words of it. See? Every song you play you should know what you're playing. Learn the words. The words will teach you the song too, they'll tell you what the thing is about. What the song is about. You have to learn it. You might not want to take time to learn the words but look at them, find out what it is all about. No, no, no, no, a lot of people if you're going to take a person's song and just start jamming on it, what are you jamming on? You don't know what you're jamming on. Come on man. Learn the song. Learn how to listen at the song. We listen different. If we learn how to listen — listen to the song. Listen to the progression. Listen to the movement on. Where is it going? What is it talking about? If we don't know the words we don't know what in the hell they're talking about. You know? All this is important in playing music. Very important. We take it literally back here. I tell many musicians, there is seven of us, six of us on the bandstand. Each one of them is a great musician, a very

good musician, and I'm good. But we've all got to play together, the six of us got to play together. We can do "Lady Be Good" you know "Lady Be Good," he knows "Lady Be Good," But we've got to do this together. We've got to do "Lady Be Good" in other words just because you know "Lady Be Good" the playing, we're all playing what we want to do ourselves but you are the music, so if we don't synchronize your parts and things to what the leader is doing then you're playing by yourself. The leader is leading us so you have to think, especially when you're reading, or when you aren't reading, because you are the music. So you have to think melodically how he's playing so you make your notes work with what's going on. So we've all got to think like one. So we can be one person. [sings] Oh sweet and lovely/Lady be good/Oh lady be good/Be good to me. We all got to think that way. Not [sings] Oh sweet and lovely. No. You're playing "Lady Be Good" but where are you? Come on. You know what I'm talking about.

MR: I do indeed.

CG: It's so important.

MR: I'm going to memorize some of your words today. Fascinating. And I'm so glad you came to meet with us today.

CG: Oh I'm glad you had me.

MR: You are the music man.

CG: You are the music. You are the music. And you just have to realize that. They have to feel that they are the music. They have to really feel it to be speaking with one voice. And when it's time for your solo you can do anything you want to do on your solo, I don't care what you do. But when you come back, one voice. And that's the way everybody can stay on track because there ain't no written music here. We are the music.

MR: All right. Thank you for your time today.

CG: Oh man, thank you for having me.

RB: Bravo.

CG: Thank you.